



THE  
INDEPENDENT PARTIES  
OF AMERICA

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*A Third Foundation for the Discarded Half*

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Founded on the Constitution and the Bill of Rights  
Governed by the written word of its communities

*with a fifty-state field guide to ballot access*

*"We hold these truths to be self-evident, that  
all men are created equal, that they are  
endowed by their Creator with certain  
unalienable Rights, that among these are  
Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.  
That to secure these rights, Governments are  
instituted among Men, deriving their just  
powers from the consent of the governed."*

The Declaration of Independence, 1776

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## **PART ONE**

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## CHAPTER 1

# The Seesaw

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Every few years, Americans are asked to believe that a change of ownership is the same thing as change. The party out of power warns that the country is being ruined. The party in power warns that things are finally being fixed and must not be interrupted. Then the voters swing, or stay home, and the seesaw tips the other way. The warnings swap microphones. The machine does not.

Look at what actually happens after a transfer of power. The new majority spends its first year blaming the old one. It passes what it can on a party-line vote. The other side campaigns on the damage. Two years later the voters, tired of the noise or the disappointment, tip the seesaw back. The new old majority spends its first year blaming the new one. Nothing that was promised gets built, because building was never really the point. The point was the seat.

You know this in your own life. If your town council spent every meeting attacking the last council, you would call it dysfunctional. If your family conducted itself the way Congress

does, you would call it a crisis. We have learned to shrug at behavior in Washington that we would never tolerate at a volunteer fire department. The shrug is itself a kind of damage. It teaches a whole country that its common life is someone else's show.

The numbers behind the shrug are stark. At any time, three out of four Americans did not vote for the current leadership. Roughly half of the voters who are allowed to vote turn out for most elections, and the half that stays home is not lazy. When pollsters ask the missing half why they left, they do not describe not caring. They describe a menu with one item on it. They describe two organized minorities competing to represent a majority that belongs to neither. The shut-out half of America is not silent. It was never given a sentence worth saying.

This book is about that half. It is about the truck driver who watches a debate and hears two men talk past the price of diesel. The nurse who hears passion about every subject except staffing. The farmer who watches both parties discover rural America every four years at the farmers market, holding a basket of produce for the camera, then never coming back to buy anything. It is about the small business owner who suspects, correctly, that the entire machine of the federal government has never once had to make payroll.

A political party is a tool. Nothing more. It is a lever, invented by practical people, for turning scattered individuals into a force that can govern. When a tool breaks, you do not honor it with a funeral. You fix it or you build a better one. The two parties in power in the United States are broken tools, and the proof is in the hands: half the country will not pick them up.

What follows is a proposal, and then a manual. The proposal is called the Independent Parties of America. It is simple on

purpose. It is built on the Constitution and the Bill of Rights, and on a decision-making method borrowed, of all places, from ranchers and farmers, the people who manage land for a living and cannot afford to manage it for a news cycle. The manual that follows the proposal is practical to the point of boredom, because boredom is where these battles are actually won. At the end of the book there is a state-by-state field guide to the real, legal, mostly unexciting process of putting new parties on the ballot in every one of the fifty states.

None of this requires a billionaire. None of it requires permission from the people it will unseat. It requires only what the founders asked of each other: that we read the documents, that we show up, and that we refuse to be managed by men who profit from our anger.

### **What this book is not**

It is not a party attack piece. This book does not care, in any final way, whether your beliefs lean left or right. It cares that they are currently homeless. It does not promise that the Independent Parties of America will agree with you. It promises something rarer: a structure in which your community, not a party committee in Washington, decides what agreement looks like.

It is not a prediction. Movements like this have risen before, and some have rotted or faded. The difference between a footnote and a founding is usually not the idea. It is the paperwork, done thoroughly, by people who showed up in February as well as November. This book spends more pages on the paperwork than on the speeches, on purpose.

And it is not a promise of ease. Anyone who tells you that breaking the two-party balance is painless has never read a state election code. But ease was never the American measure. What mattered was whether a thing could be done. What one honest

reading of this book should leave you with is not inspiration, exactly. It is the specific, sobering discovery that every legal roadblock between a frustrated half of the country and its own political party is made of signatures, calendars, and filing forms. Paper cuts both ways.

**FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Think of the last election you watched from the sidelines. What would have had to be on the ballot, or in the room, for you to have shown up?*

*Who speaks for you now, when a decision gets made two thousand miles away? Name the person, if you can.*

*If half your town stopped voting, what do you think the winners would do differently? What do they do now?*

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## **PART TWO**

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## CHAPTER 2

# The Machinery of the Duel

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It is worth being precise about the enemy, because the enemy is not a man and not a cabal. It is a balance. Two parties, grown old in mutual ownership of the same government, have settled into a posture that looks like war and functions like a cartel. They fight over the margin, and the margin is where the money is. Nobody who owns half of something wants to break the thing in half.

Consider how much of our politics is actually addressed to you. A campaign is addressed to you for a few weeks, in the language of fear and urgency, because fear turns out the believers. Governance is addressed to donors, to lobbyists, to the calendar in Congress, to the next election. Between campaigns, you are not a group anyone has to please. You are an audience. The record here is blunt: representatives spend a wildly oversized share of their time raising money rather than studying the issues they vote on, and

the people they call first are not the people they represent.

The two parties did not arrive at this posture by betrayal. They arrived because the rewards pointed that way, which is more lasting and less forgivable. In any district drawn to be safely red or safely blue, the only election that matters is the primary, and primaries are decided by the most committed ten percent. So the machine learns, election after election, to serve the ten percent that shows up angry. The general election becomes a crowning with a budget. The forty percent in the middle, and the fifty percent on the couch, are shut out by the very structure. Both parties know it. Their behavior proves they know it.

Then there is the deeper lock: the rules are written by the people already in office. Ballot access laws in most states were not handed down at Philadelphia. They were written, amended, and tightened by legislatures controlled by the two parties in power, and their effect, whether or not you accept their stated intent, is that newcomers face petition thresholds, filing fees, and deadlines that the parties in power never face at all. A major party collects signatures exactly once, sometime before the American revolution of your grandparents. A new party collects them every cycle, or disappears. The field is not level. The field was graded.

Here is the part the two-party machine prefers not to discuss: none of it is secret. Every threshold, every deadline, every fee is public. The wall around American politics is a legal wall, built in plain sight, and legal walls have doors. The last third of this book is, in effect, a list of the doors. The reason more people have not walked through them is not the height of the wall. It is the story we have all agreed to believe about the wall.

The story goes like this: a third party can never win, so a vote for one is a vote thrown away. Notice the sleight of hand. The argument takes the two-party outcome as a law of nature, when it

is a consequence of rules, habits, and spirit. It asks you to judge a movement by its first election rather than its tenth. And it quietly assumes that the only possible prize is immediate victory, as if the previous century of American reform had taught us nothing. Women voted in local races years before they won the president's attention. The people who fought to end slavery lost thousands of elections on their way to winning the country. The measure of a third movement is not whether it captures the capital in its first season. It is whether it captures the argument.

There is a final piece of the machine worth naming, because it is the one that works on your own heart. The two-party machine needs you angry. Anger is the cheapest turnout drug on the market. It requires no policy, no compromise, no results. It can be harvested nightly. This is why the politics you are served is tuned less to solve problems than to keep your blood at a rolling simmer, decade after decade. A generation that is always furious is a generation that shows up at the polls every time but never at the table. Consensus does not trend. Conversation does not sell. The seesaw is not just a governing failure. It is a business model.

#### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*The rules were written by the people they protect. What would you expect to find, if you looked?*

*Is a wall still a wall if anyone can climb it, but everyone has agreed to believe they cannot?*

*What would the politics on your screen look like if it wanted you calm instead of angry? Who would pay for that version?*

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## CHAPTER 3

# The Discarded Half

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Before proposing a fix, it is worth staring honestly at the wound. Half of America does not vote. Both parties have built entire strategies around that fact, and neither has any intention of changing it. Chasing people who do not vote is expensive and hard to predict; whipping up fear among regular voters is cheap and steady. So the campaigns let the sleeping half sleep, and the political scientists file them under 'not caring', and the country absorbs the idea that absence means consent.

But ask the absent why they stay home and you will hear something that should embarrass a self-governing people. They will tell you that nobody ran for them. Not that politics is boring, or the weather was bad. That the choice on offer did not include them. A single mother working two jobs hears a debate about the middle class that begins somewhere above her income. A young welder hears both parties talk about the dignity of labor, and neither one mentions the robotic arm welding doors on the line where he works. A retired teacher hears her pension discussed as

a line item by men who will never need one. These are not people who do not care. They are people no one has convinced yet, and no one has seriously tried.

The discarded half is also, and this is the part with consequences, the half with the least guardrails around its anger. People who believe the system hears them will usually work within it. People who are certain it never will start shopping for alternatives, some reasonable, some not. You do not have to approve of every political delusion running loose in America to understand where the soil came from. Big organizations that stop listening do not create silence. They create markets, and something always arrives to serve a market.

There is an older American tradition for what to do with a discarded half, and it is not despair. It is founding. The country you are sitting in was, from the point of view of the world's arrangement of power in 1776, a third-party movement. So was the movement that ended slavery, the movement that gave women the ballot, the movement that organized labor into a bargaining force, and the movement that ended segregation by law. None of them began with a majority. Every one of them began with a minority that refused to accept that the existing menu of choices was the menu of choices.

The difference between their moment and ours is not the depth of the grievance. It is how exact the alternative is. Unhappiness without a structure turns sour. Unhappiness with a structure is called a party. That is the whole of the problem this book takes up: to give the discarded half of America a structure of its own, one that cannot be captured by the same rewards that captured the other two, because the structure itself routes around them. The next four chapters describe that structure. It has five working parts. A name. A written promise that comes from communities rather than to them. A gate that candidates pass

through by listening, not by donating. A set of questions applied to every policy before it becomes law. And a self-destruct clause on every promise made, so that no law outlives its honesty.

**FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Who is on the couch in your own house, and what did the menu on offer miss?*

*Is the anger around you closer to fuel or to smoke? What is it burning?*

*What did your grandparents' generation fix without either of today's parties? Who paid for it?*

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## **PART THREE**

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## CHAPTER 4

# The Independent Parties of America

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The Independent Parties of America, the IPA, is proposed as a truly independent party in American politics, and everything about it, from the party's own record to the full text of this book, lives at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org). Its foundation is the Constitution of the United States and the Bill of Rights, held as the highest law of the land and as the shared property of every faction within it. Its method is a body of practice called holistic management, adapted from the working landscape to the way people govern themselves. Its one requirement to run is not wealth, family name, or famous backers. It is authorship: to run on the IPA ticket, you must have helped write your community's own statement of how it wants to live.

Take those in order, because the order is the argument.

First, the Constitution. Most new movements treat the founding documents as scenery, invoked at rallies and ignored in practice. The IPA does the opposite: it makes them the

load-bearing wall. Every candidate, before signing off on any policy or voting for anyone else's, is responsible for checking that the measure sits inside the Constitution and the Bill of Rights. This is not for show. It is the party's answer to the deepest fear in American political life, which is that the rules themselves will be bent by whoever holds temporary power. A party that makes loyalty to the Constitution a candidate's personal, published duty is a party that has chosen its referee before the game begins. It also hands every IPA voter a standard they can check from their kitchen table, no degree required.

Second, the method. Holistic management was developed by people who manage grazing land, and its first discovery is embarrassing to politicians: most failures are not failures of effort or even of resources. They are failures of context. A rancher who rotates cattle without a clear picture of the landscape he wants in a hundred years will fine-tune his way into a desert, one sensible decision at a time. Politics in America has been optimizing without a context for two generations. The IPA refuses to make a decision until the community it serves has written down the context. That context names the life its people want, the well-being that must support it, and the land and water and air that must still sustain both centuries from now. Every policy is then tested against that written word, not against a poll.

Third, the gate. Here is the part that makes the IPA truly different, and it is worth slowing down for. To become a candidate of the Independent Parties of America, at any level, you must have been involved in the creation of your community's holistic context. Not fund it. Not back it. Help write it. Sit in the room with your neighbors, across every line the country has learned to sort by, and labor over the words that describe what all of you actually want. Only then may your name go on the ticket. A party that requires its candidates to sit through the slow work of consensus is not a party that can be purchased after breakfast. The proof is

not a donation. It is attendance. Each candidate's context and record live in the open at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org).

From that single gate, everything else about the party follows, and much that plagues the existing system is quietly cut away. There is no national platform handed down, because the platform is the constitution plus fifty thousand local contexts. The national party does not advise candidates how to vote on the issues; it could not, since a vote that is correct in one county's context may be wrong in the next one down the road. What the national party holds instead is a standard of process: did you write the context, do you test your votes against it, can you show your community the work? A candidate can be liberal or conservative or hard to pin down and hold the ticket, so long as the process is honored. The IPA is not a camp. It is a craft.

Financing follows the same logic of self-restraint. Each IPA candidate donates a fifth of the funds they raise for their own election for running on the party, and that is the entire revenue model. No corporate bank accounts, no leadership PAC money, no secret-money washing. The party exists on a twenty percent tithe of campaigns small enough to be neighborhood affairs, which keeps the whole structure, like the old principle of tithing itself, honest through poverty. The money is used for one purpose only: to help the next community, and the next candidate after that, build their context and find the ballot. It is a party designed to make more of itself, not to pile up power.

And the party tells its own candidates the most unpopular sentence in American politics: we do not promise you a fixed party line, and we do not promise you a job for life. Each community is responsible for evaluating how its own elected official voted and how they moved the community toward its context, and that evaluation is published before every election at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org), in plain sight, for the neighbors to read. If the record shows the

officeholder ignored the electorate, the community does not need a national committee to tell it what everyone can see. The ticket dies at home, quietly, where accountability was always supposed to live.

It is a modest architecture, and that is the point. America does not need a third party with a second platform. It needs a different machine entirely: one whose units of power are communities, whose proof is listening, whose bible is a document older and calmer than any of us, and whose campaigns are too small to buy and too local to capture. What follows is the machine, part by part.

#### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*If you had to bet, which would reach this party first: money, sweet talk, or tiredness? What would you build to catch that one?*

*The proof is showing up. What work would you personally require of a candidate before you would trust them with your name?*

*Who in your county could write a sentence about the good life that both sides would sign? Have you ever actually asked them?*

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## CHAPTER 5

# The Community's Word

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Everything in the IPA rests on a single document, written locally, owned locally, and tested endlessly: the community holistic context. Before explaining how one is made, it is worth sitting with what one is. A community holistic context is a declaration of how the people living in a community want their lives to be. Not a policy platform. Not a wish list. Not a list of complaints. A description, in plain words, of the life a community intends to have, written carefully enough to steer every decision that follows it.

The word community does a lot of work here, and honestly. It can mean a town of four hundred or a city of four hundred thousand. It can mean a county, a school district, a ward, a rural county seat with one stoplight. The unit is defined by the people who live in it, not by a mapmaker in a state capital, because the whole premise of the book is that governance should be sized to the people it touches. The context belongs to whoever shares the consequences.

A proper context answers three questions, and only three, in the order given.

How do the people want their lives to be, based on what they value most: in their culture, in their daily needs, and in their spirit.

What has to be produced, and what must people do, to live such lives.

And what must the resource base, the land, the water, the air, the soil itself, look like hundreds of years from now so that people then can still live such lives.

Notice what is missing: any candidate, any party, any policy. A context is written as if the election had not happened yet, because its job is to judge the election.

The writing rules are strict, and each one has a reason sharpened by long practice. A context cannot contain any decision already made. The moment we have chosen, we have stopped describing the life we want and started defending a choice, and the document dies of politics. It cannot contain prejudice against any future action or tool; the community describes the outcome it wants, and leaves the how open to evidence, because the technology we forbid today may be the thing that saves us tomorrow. And nothing in it is counted out in numbers or ranked by importance; the numbers come later, in testing, where they can be argued with and replaced. The context is the constitution of the community's intentions, not its budget.

One more rule, the hardest and the most important: the context is created by consensus, not compromise. The difference decides everything. Compromise splits the difference and leaves everyone somewhat betrayed; consensus means the group keeps talking until it finds words that all of them, including every person

holding veto power over the declaration, can actually stand inside. That requires a meeting leader with real skill and the patience of a saint, and it requires the room to actually hold the whole community. All races, all colors, all religions, both sexes, every age old enough to carry the consequence, and specifically, on purpose, the people with the power to say no. A context written without its veto holders is not a context. It is a press release.

What does such a document look like? It is a plain statement of how the people want their lives to be, and it covers three things at once: the social, how they want to live together; the economic, how they want to make their living; and the environmental, what the land and water around them must look like hundreds of years from now for that life to still be possible. It is written both near term and far, and it is written so that anyone with the power to block it has a hand in writing it. It looks like this, more or less: We live in a town where a family can survive on one honest income and still sit down to dinner together. Our kids graduate able to read a contract, balance a checkbook, and disagree without contempt. The river runs clean enough to swim in, and the farms upstream are still farming in a hundred years. We know our neighbors' names. We can afford to get sick. We raise our own food where we can and know the people who raise the rest. Government here is close enough to look in the eye. Nothing in that paragraph mentions a single law. Every law proposed in that town, for the next century, could be tested against it.

Once a community has declared its word, the structure grows upward from it, and this is the part that quietly rearranges how American power is split between local, state, and national levels. Each community does not send its whole context upward; the people who wrote it stand for election, and the community votes in its representative to sit at the next table. The neighborhood sends its elected representative to the city's table. The city sends its elected representative to the county's. County representatives

gather to write the state's context, and state representatives gather to write the nation's. Every tier uses the same veto rules and the same quality-of-life standard, so the national context is written, hand to hand, by people the local communities chose themselves. Power flows upward as language, not as money. A senator from this system arrives in Washington already fluent in the dialect of the people who sent her, because the people who sent her are the ones who wrote the words she ran on.

Is this naive? It is certainly slower than a press release. But compare it honestly with the alternative, which is what America does now: each party writes a platform every four years, written by consultants to poll well, honored for a news cycle, and then measured against nothing. A community that has written down, in its own voice, what it wants its life to be, and then hires its politicians to test every vote against that page, has done something the platforms cannot. It has created a contract with a conscience, and a memory longer than a news cycle.

#### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*What would your community's sentence be? Try writing one tonight, before anyone helps you.*

*Who holds a veto where you live, and when did anyone last put them in a room with the people they can veto?*

*Where have you seen consensus done for real? What did it cost, and was it worth it?*

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## CHAPTER 6

# The Candidate's Burden

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Now the gate in detail. Suppose you are a person who wants to help your community by entering its politics, at any level: council, county, state, or the Congress itself. The Independent Parties of America asks you to do four things before your name ever reaches a ballot. They are simple to state and demanding to live.

First, identify the whole under management. Who can actually vote in the election you are entering? Not who you wish would vote. Who is registered, where the lines are drawn, which offices appear on that ballot. This sounds like keeping the books; it is really a stance. You are declaring that you intend to answer to the entire electorate, not to the sliver that agrees with you. Every later step assumes you got this one honest.

Second, invite the whole. Everyone with a stake in the community is asked and called to the table where the context will be written. The invitation extends, as the Constitution does, across race, color, religion, and sex, across every age group able to vote, and it reaches, on purpose, for the people with the power to

veto whatever the room produces. If the county commissioners can block what you plan, the commissioners are in the room. If the school board, the farmers, the faith communities, the unions, the Chamber of Commerce each hold a piece of the future, each holds a chair. The gathering is the proof. You cannot skip it, buy it, or fake it, because the third step checks your work.

Third, write the context. With a meeting leader, the gathered community states its purpose and then labors through the three questions from the last chapter until it has words it can live inside. This is where the candidate's real campaign happens, and it is plain on purpose: folding chairs, bad coffee, long arguments about a single sentence, the slow miracle of forty strangers finding language they can all sign. Nobody waves to a camera in this room. What happens instead is stranger and stronger. By the end, the future officeholder has heard the community describe its own life, in its own words, with the veto holders nodding, and the community has watched the candidate sit still and take it in.

Fourth, declare. When the context stands, those who took part in writing it may notify IPA headquarters through [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org) of their desire to run on the IPA ticket, submitting their community's context as proof of involvement. If several people from the same community seek the nomination, they do what Americans do: they organize among their own and vote for their preferred candidate, and the winner goes forward as the IPA nominee for that community.

Then the campaign proper, which under this system looks almost nothing like a modern campaign. There is no platform to defend, only a context to honor. The candidate's task is not to shout opponents but to persuade the independent voters of the electorate that they are the right person to move the community toward the life it has already described for itself, in how people live together, how they make a living, and how they treat the land

around them, near term and far. The debates write themselves. Instead of trading insults, the candidates explain, again and again, how they would test this decision or that one against the community's own page. Voters, for the first time in a long while, are watching people they know argue about their future in words they helped choose.

And after the election, the burden does not lift; it tightens. The officeholder is expected to create policy and to judge everyone else's policy by the community's context, using a fixed set of questions that the next chapter sets out. Every vote is measured against the written word. Every year, the record of those measurements is published at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org) for the community to read before the next election. The voters themselves are the audit committee. This is the plain way the two-party grip gets beaten: not by one big victory, but by neighbors who can read, year after year. It does not lift; it tightens. The hold the two parties have on power is loosened by nothing so much as a record anyone can check. An IPA officeholder who drifts from the context is not corrected by the party. The party has nothing to say. The push comes from the neighbors, at the ballot box, with the record in their hands.

It is worth asking why anyone with ambition would accept burdens this heavy. The answer is the same reason a person joins a volunteer fire department rather than a for-profit security firm: because the work is real. Politics as currently practiced is a career with a salary and no product. Politics under this system is a craft with a visible product, a community visibly nearer to its own declared quality of life. The people this gate selects are not the ones who want to be somebody. It selects, over time, the ones who want to get something done, and history suggests those are the only ones worth electing.

**FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Could you sit through it? Be honest.*

*Is there anyone you would trust who could? What makes you sure?*

*What would you need to see in a neighbor's record to forgive them  
one honest mistake?*

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## CHAPTER 7

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# The Seven Questions

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A context without a testing process is a wish. The IPA method is a set of seven questions, asked in order, of every policy a candidate would create and every policy a candidate is asked to vote for. They come to politics from the working landscape, where they have been tested for four decades on decisions involving land, money, animals, and human communities, and their virtue is that they are hard to fool. An answer that sounds good usually fails one of the seven. A decision that passes all seven is usually, though not always, a good decision. Either way, the questions are public property. Any voter can run them. Any editor can run them. That is what makes them politically dangerous to the status quo.

Question one: cause and effect - does this action address the root cause of the problem?

Washington's default is the symptom, because symptoms are visible and causes are structural, and a response to a symptom can be announced on Friday and forgotten by Monday. A farm subsidy that props up the price does not ask why the price collapsed. A

border measure does not ask why people come. A tax credit does not ask why the thing needed credit to survive. The first question exists to embarrass all of that. It forces the debate one level down, to the layer where the actual problem lives, which is exactly the layer most laws were written to avoid.

Question two: the weak link.

a. The social form: could this action, due to prevailing beliefs, create a weak link in the chain of actions leading towards your community's Quality of Life in your community's Holistic Context?

b. The biological form: does this action address the weakest point in the life cycle of the organism?

c. The financial form: does this action strengthen the weakest link in the chain of production?

Every chain of action has a weakest link, and strengthening a strong link does nothing. Laws that ignore what people believe tend to fail in the place where belief is firmest. In living systems, the weakest point of the life cycle is where a herd, a crop, or a town actually breaks, no matter how healthy the rest of it looks. And a subsidy to the middle of a supply chain while the ends are starving is money spent strengthening the wrong link.

Question three: marginal reaction - greatest return towards Quality of Life for time and money spent.

Of the time and money this action costs, which choice gives the greatest return towards quality of life? Not the biggest overall return; the greatest return on the next dollar and the next hour, which is the only return anyone can actually spend. Politics keeps reaching for grand, slow, expensive gestures when three small quick ones would have moved the community further. The marginal reaction is the habit of people who cannot afford to be

wrong twice in the same year.

Question four: gross profit analysis - which enterprise goes the most towards covering the overhead of the community?

Every community carries shared costs: roads, schools, water, the fire hall, the courthouse roof. Not every economic activity in the community covers its share of that load. The fourth question asks, before a community spends or hands out rewards, which of its enterprises actually generates the surplus that pays for the rest.

Question five: energy and money, source and use - will it take your community towards your community's Quality of Life goals? The energy, the power, must not be addictive in use.

Where does the energy and the money come from, and where do they go? An action funded by money pulled away from the community itself is borrowing against the very life it claims to serve. And there is a hard rule on top of the arithmetic: the energy, the power, must not be addictive in use. Anything that needs more of itself every year just to feel normal, whether it is a fuel, a budget, or the authority of an office, is no longer a tool. It is a habit, and a habit sets the goals instead of serving them.

Question six: sustainability - towards or away from the future resource base described in your community's Holistic Context?

Does this action move towards, or away from, the land, the water, the air, and the soil as the context says they must look hundreds of years from now? A decision can pass every other test and still fail here, because the resource base does not argue back; it simply leaves.

Question seven: society and culture - how do you feel about this action now? Will it lead to the Quality of Life your community desires? Will it adversely affect the lives of others?

The gut check, and the one no spreadsheet can do. Run the action in your mind, live with it for a day, and watch what your own stomach does. It also looks past the community's edge: an action that helps at home and damages lives somewhere else has not passed. The seventh question is where the community admits what it actually believes, and occasionally changes it.

Run any bill now in the news through the seven and watch what happens. Most proposed laws fail at question one and never needs the rest; it was aimed at a symptom because the cause had a lobby. Some measures survive six questions and die at the seventh, which is usually the public's own verdict arriving a decade early. The method does not guarantee agreement. Two honest people can run the same seven questions and land in different places, and in a party of independents they will. But they will disagree in a shared language, about shared evidence, against a written context they both helped create. That is what consensus-building actually looks like: not the absence of disagreement, but the presence of a common test. It is the difference between an argument and a feud.

#### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Take one thing your government did last year. Run the seven questions yourself, alone, on paper. Where did it fail first?*

*Which of the seven would have changed the most votes, if it had been asked out loud?*

*Who benefits from questions never being asked in order?*

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## CHAPTER 8

# The Fail-Safe

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Here is the newest item in the whole design, and in some ways the most far-reaching: the IPA expects that every policy it passes will cause harm. Not might. Will. Every law ever written has produced consequences its authors did not intend, and a long view of any century of lawmaking confirms that the damage from the unintended ones regularly rivals the good from the intended ones. The American response has been to act surprised, then defensive, then frozen in place. The IPA response is to plan for the surprise in advance, on the face of the bill.

The system is the fail-safe clause, and it is a condition of the ticket: any and all policies created or voted on must carry one, filed where anyone can read it at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org). The clause names, at the time of writing, the negative consequences the authors can see coming. It sets up the watching that will catch them, with real signs and real check-in times. And it contains an instruction that carries itself out: the moment an identified unintended negative consequence is confirmed, the clause fires, the policy is

immediately cancelled and void, and the makers must return and re-debate the thing from scratch, in public, with the evidence on the table. This will most often be triggered by a challenge in the courts, where the judiciary has the final say on whether a law can no longer be used in a prosecution because of the unintended consequence clause.

Sit with how that turns the normal physics of lawmaking upside down. Under current practice, a law is a one-way door: passed with celebration, defended with the money already spent on it, fixed only under scandal, and taken off the books almost never, because taking a law off the books is treated as confessing failure, and confessing failure ends careers. Programs outlive their purposes the way ivy outlives the frame it climbs. The fail-safe flips the default. Ending and self-repeal become the planned response to evidence of harm, not the shameful exception. A lawmaker who votes for a policy with a fail-safe is not betting their career on the policy being right. They are demonstrating, publicly, how wrong they are prepared to discover it to be.

Notice also what the clause does to the writing of laws. If authors know the alarm lines will be watched, they think harder at the drafting table, where thinking is cheap. The best fail-safe is the one that never trips because the consequence it watched for was designed out at the start. The method is the old engineering habit, taught wherever people build things that must not fail: specify the failure modes before the first weld. Lawmaking is the only major American business that ships without a recall clause. This one clause would give it what every other industry has had for a century.

And notice, finally, what it does to trust. The deepest wound in American civic life is not any particular policy. It is the discovery, repeated so often it has become an belief, that nobody in power will ever say the words this did not work. The fail-safe clause is

those words, pre-written, stamped by a notary, and attached to every vote. A party that campaigns on its own ability to fail is hard to distrust, and a community that knows its laws come with self-destruct buttons can afford to let its government try things. Spreading decisions out, trying things, honest failure, fast correction: that is not a slogan. That is the description of every system that has ever actually learned.

### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Should a law that harms people apologize automatically, or should someone have to stand up and do it in person? Which of those keeps the rest honest?*

*What would fall apart in your town if its laws could retire themselves? What would finally get built?*

*Write the fail-safe clause for something you want. What would you watch for, and who would ring the bell?*

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## **PART FOUR**

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## CHAPTER 9

# The Field Manual

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Everything to this point has been the argument. Now comes the work. This chapter is a field manual: the sequence a real group of citizens follows to take the Independent Parties of America from a kitchen-table idea to a line on an actual ballot. It is written to be followed, not admired. If you lose this book, the same content should someday exist at every IPA county chapter, dog-eared, because this is the part that actually founds anything.

### **Step one: the founding circle**

A party begins with a founding circle: three to twelve people who know each other well enough to survive a long project, drawn on purpose from more than one camp of the community. Not twelve people who agree about everything; twelve people whose disagreements will be useful. The founders do not need money, permission, or a lawyer for this step. They need a date, a room, and a refusal to leave until three things exist: a name, a set of bylaws, and a calendar.

*Name it carefully. Check the state's rules on party names first; several states bar names too similar to existing parties, and at least two bar the word independent outright. Check what already exists at the county election office before falling in love with any wording. The name has to fit on a petition, survive a complaint, and look honest on a ballot next to two brands with two hundred years of advertising behind them. Plain and specific beats clever. Whatever name you choose, attach IPA as a prefix or suffix so voters can identify the party's candidates at a glance. The last section of this book tells you your state's rules in detail; read that entry before you print anything.*

Bylaws are less romantic and more important than a name. They are the party's constitution in small form: how officers are chosen, how candidates are backed, and how the local party relates to the state and national bodies. They also set how the loyalty-to-the-Constitution check is performed on every backed candidate's policies, and how the whole thing can be amended. Keep them short enough that members actually read them, and honest enough that they would survive being read aloud in a courtroom by someone hostile to you.

*Bylaws should cover, at minimum: the party's purpose, tied openly to the Constitution and Bill of Rights; membership; officers and their terms; how the party decides to endorse; the duty of every endorsed candidate to help write the community's holistic context; the policy testing discipline of the seven questions and the fail-safe clause; finances, including the twenty percent tithe to party administration; and the amendment procedure.*

The calendar is the step everyone skips, and skipping it is why most new parties die in year one. Deadlines in election law are not suggestions, and many of them land months before the election everyone cares about. From the first founding meeting, the circle writes down every date the state will demand: petition start,

petition end, filing windows, party meeting dates, sign-off dates. Tape it to the wall. Miss one and the whole year can be gone; election law does not do extensions.

### **Step two: money without masters**

The party's revenue model is written into its design: every candidate on the ticket donates twenty percent of the funds they raise for their own election for running on the party, and that is the entire plan. No corporate bank accounts. No committee money-washing. No billionaire angel. All of these can be used at first, but it will not take long for wealthy supporters to see that their generosity buys them no special treatment. What it may buy them is appreciation in their own community, for helping the three quarters of America that was never heard finally be heard. This is modest by design, and modest has teeth: a party funded by tithes from neighborhood campaigns cannot be captured by a single check. A party that lives on twenty percent of small receipts also has no reason to sell its candidates' votes. Its income scales with the number of communities it serves, not the size of any one donor.

The federal paperwork, for context: a political party committee must register with the Federal Election Commission once it takes in contributions or spends over \$1,000 in a calendar year, and the law allows only ten days after crossing that line to file. The threshold is designed to be low, which means the barrier to founding is designed to be low. There is no wealth test to found a party in America. There is only a form, a filing cabinet, and people willing to sign their names. Working templates for all of it, from FEC registration to bylaws, sit at [usaipa.org](http://usaipa.org).

Before a single dollar moves, decide on the housekeeping: a dedicated bank account, a named money keeper who is good with spreadsheets and bad at decorating the truth, and a paper trail a

hostile auditor could follow. Campaign finance law is forgiving of small parties that keep records and harsh without mercy toward sloppy ones. The habit that keeps you out of trouble costs a few hours a month. The alternative costs everything the party is for.

### **Step three: the first context**

Now the party builds its first product: a community holistic context. This is the proving step, the one that separates a real IPA chapter from a social media group with a logo. Choose the room with care: a public building, a night that does not fight church or shift work, and chairs enough for people you expect to disagree with. Invite across every line the country sorts by, and reach specifically for the people who hold veto power over the community's decisions: the officeholders, the major employers, the faith leaders, the farm bureau, the union hall, the school board, the merchants. A context written without its veto holders is a press release, not a context.

Borrow or train a meeting leader who has actually done this. The meeting leader's job is not to steer the content; it is to protect the process, keep the three questions in order, catch decisions sneaking into what should be a description, and hold the room at consensus rather than compromise. Good meeting leading is the difference between a document that steers a community for a generation and a document that dies in the parking lot. This leader is often a paid position, and raising money for that pay is one of the first things a founding circle does.

The work itself is four movements. One: state the purpose. This is the Holistic Context Statement of Purpose for the City of Anywhere. Our purpose is to look after our community's people, its work and money, and its land and water. Two: how do the people want their lives to be, based on what they value most, in their culture, in their daily needs, and in their spirit. Three: what

has to be produced, and what must people do, to live such lives. Four: what must the resource base look like hundreds of years from now so that people then can still live such lives.

Guard the writing rules. No decision already made. No prejudice against any future action or tool. Nothing counted out in numbers, and nothing ranked by importance. Consensus, not compromise. When the room stalls, and it will, the meeting leader earns their keep by separating the sentence that describes the life from the sentence that defends a policy. When the room finishes, print it. Publish it. Read it at the next council meeting. The context is now the community's measuring stick, and the party's only product.

*A context that works reads like the community talking, not a committee concluding. If a sentence could appear unchanged in any town in America, cut it. If it could not be signed by the people in the back row, those people were not in the room.*

### **Step four: finding the candidates**

The IPA does not recruit the way other parties do. It does not look for candidates and hand them a platform. It looks for listeners, and the listening produces the candidates. Everyone who sat through the writing of the context has, by that act, earned the right to seek the ticket. Those who want the nomination notify the party and submit the community's context as proof of involvement; if several step forward, the community organizes and votes among them, and the winner carries the nomination.

Expect the first pool to be small and strange. It will include a farmer, a nurse, maybe a retired teacher, a person nobody at the state capital has ever heard of. Good. Look for the three signals that matter under this system: did they actually sit through the writing, can they explain the community's context in their own words without notes, and would their life bear the publishing of

their votes each year against the page. Everything a modern consultant looks for, the polishing, the fundraising list, the haircut, is noise. The gate already ran.

First races should be chosen like an investor chooses first purchases. Local, winnable, and visible. A county commission seat, a school board, a mayor's office in a small city. The goal of the first cycle is not to storm Washington. It is to produce one officeholder whose published record shows the seven questions being used in office, a fail-safe clause riding on their proposals, and a community that can see, with its own eyes, a politician clearly moving the town toward its own declared quality of life. One honest officeholder is worth more than a thousand national arguments online, and it is the only foundation a national party can actually stand on.

### **Step five: the ballot**

Everything to this point would fit inside one county. The ballot is where the county meets the state, and the state, as the back of this book shows, has fifty different handshakes. Some states want a handful of signatures and a form; others want tens of thousands, spread across the map, gathered inside narrow windows, delivered at a party meeting rather than by petition. Read your state's entry in the back of this book. Then call the local election office, which will usually mail you the current forms and deadlines for free, and ask for the new party packet. Treat every published summary, including this book's, as a first map and every election office as the final word.

Whatever the state's method, three practices are universal. Start early: petition windows are short, signatures age, and summer calendars fill fast. Going over the top: signatures die during checking at an ugly rate, so a well-tested rule of thumb is to collect a generous buffer above the requirement, commonly

twenty to thirty percent more than the stated minimum. And keep records: names, dates, addresses, who gathered what and when, because challenges happen and sloppy petitions are how the firewall of the people already in office does its quiet work.

Expect the two parties in power to treat your petition as a lawsuit, because in most states that is what it is. Signatures get challenged one by one; the people who carry the petitions get thrown out on tiny rule details; small paperwork errors end whole drives. This is not bullying, exactly. It is the firewall of the people already in office doing what it was built to do. The counters are the same three: early, oversized, documented. A petition drive that is all three is very hard to kill, and killing it in public has costs the challengers must also weigh.

When the petition survives, file everything on time, sign off on your nominees by whatever method your bylaws set out, and go run. Then, whatever the result, do the least glamorous and most important thing in this whole book: come back and do it again next cycle. Ballot status spoils. Most states yank it the moment a party dips below a vote threshold or skips an election. The states that are gentle, and the back of this book names them, are where a national movement should take root first, on purpose, like a farmer choosing soil to plant in.

### **Step six: in office, the record**

The last step never ends. From the day the first IPA officeholder takes the oath, the party's product is a public record. Every vote is tested against the community's context, every policy carries its fail-safe clause, and every judgment is shown in the seven questions' own language. All of it is published online where the community can read it before the next election. The community, not the party, is the audit committee. It will notice drift before headquarters does, and it will correct what it elects,

which is the whole theory of the thing working as designed. When the record is honest and the results are visible, the second candidate is easier to find than the first. That building up, more than any campaign, is how a movement becomes an institution.

**FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Who are your twelve? You can probably name eight already.*

*What belongs on the first page of your bylaws, in your town, with your people?*

*Which room in your county could actually hold the whole argument?*

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## PART FIVE

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## CHAPTER 10

# Fifty Doors

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The United States has no national ballot and no national office that registers parties. There are fifty secretaries of state, fifty election codes, and fifty ideas about what a political party is allowed to be. A movement that can survive all fifty rulebooks is a movement with roots no law can pull up. The pages that follow walk through every state in A-to-Z order: what a new party must do to get on the ballot, how its candidates qualify, and what it must do to keep its place. The entries are short on purpose. They are meant to be read with a phone in one hand and your county election office's number in the other.

A note on how to use them. First, find your own state and read it twice. Second, find the gentle states. A few of them, you will notice, ask almost nothing: no petition, no fee, sometimes no paperwork beyond a letter from the party chairman. These are the seedbeds. A national strategy that begins where the door is already open does not need to break down a single door to exist, and existence, in the beginning, is the entire game. Third, find the

hard states and read them anyway, because the hard ones tell you exactly what the parties in power fear enough to forbid, which is a kind of compliment.

And keep one fact in view as you read. Nowhere in fifty states will you find a requirement that a new party be rich, famous, or approved by the ones already in power. The gates are made of signatures, calendars, and filing forms. They yield to organization. They have always yielded to organization. The only thing they never yield to is the belief that they will not.

#### **FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*Find your state. Read the entry twice. What does your door really ask for?*

*If you had to start in a neighboring state instead, which one, and what does your answer tell you about where you live?*

*What does it mean that the easiest doors and the hardest doors sit a few hundred miles apart?*

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CHAPTER 11

# The Onward Road

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Every warning this book deserves, it has already given itself. A new party can be captured, and parties this spread out are harder to capture but not impossible. It can fracture, since a structure that respects local contexts will sometimes watch two contexts collide. It can be outlived by its own slogan, or hollowed into a brand, or reduced to a ballot line rented out to the highest bidder, which is the fate that has found more than one reform movement before it. The founders of this one should write the failure modes on the wall next to the calendar, because a party built on the expectation of unintended consequences ought to apply that expectation to itself first.

But weigh the alternative honestly. The seesaw does not need your participation to keep swinging; it swings fine on its own. What it needs is your giving up, your settled conclusion that the menu is the horizon, that the anger is a lifestyle, that half the country must stay without a voice because two organizations that agree on one thing, that they will last forever, say so. A person can

accept that. A free people cannot afford it.

The founders of this republic pulled off a stranger, harder thing than anything proposed here, with worse communications, smaller populations, and a king across an ocean. They were, most of them, local men: farmers, lawyers, printers, ferry operators, men who could be found at home. The system they built assumed that local people, talking in good faith, could govern themselves through written words held in common. That belief is the actual American tradition. Everything else, the consultants, the permanent campaign, the anger economy, is a recent invention, and inventions can be outgrown.

So here is the whole book in one paragraph. Half of America has no voice, not because it is silent but because it was never offered a sentence worth signing. The Independent Parties of America is that sentence, written not by a committee in Washington but by communities, in their own words. It is tested by seven honest questions, protected with fail-safe clauses, paid for by tithes instead of masters, and bounded always by the Constitution and the Bill of Rights. The path to it runs through folding chairs and petition clipboards, through fifty state rulebooks that yield to anyone patient enough to read them. No permission is required. No permission was ever required. The consent of the governed has to be given, and given, and given again, by the governed, or it is not consent at all. It is scenery.

Start with your county. Start this winter, before the next election makes everyone busy with the old menu. Call the people who disagree with you first, because the room is not real without them, and the room is the whole point. Write down what your community wants its life to be. Then go put it on the ballot, in the manner your state plainly provides, and let the seesaw rock without you. The country was never going to be saved by the next election. It is saved, when it is saved, by the next founding.

The door is made of paper. Bring a pen.

The annex that follows covers every state in A-to-Z order. It begins with a short note on sources and on the one federal filing that matters, then gives each state's requirements in plain language. Verify everything with your state election office before acting; the entries are a map, not the territory.

**FOR YOUR OWN CONCLUSIONS**

*What would have to be true in ten years for you to judge this book wrong? Write it down. Check later.*

*What would you attempt first if you knew it could not be mocked?*

*Who would you need to forgive before a room like this could work? Start there.*

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**ANNEX**

# **The Fifty States**

*Ballot Access, State by State*

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Every law described in this annex was drawn from public summaries of each state's election statutes, chiefly the compendium maintained by Ballotpedia, and from federal election rules. It is included so that no reader can say the door was hidden. The numbers matter less than the lesson they teach: in most of America, the barrier to a new party is not money and it is not popularity. It is paperwork, patience, and signatures. A motivated precinct can clear these hurdles. Most never try.

Read your state's entry, then verify it. Election laws change, secretaries of state reissue handbooks, and deadlines shift with every legislative session. Your county election office will usually hand you the current forms for the asking, free. This annex is a map of the terrain as it stood when the book was compiled. It is orientation, not legal advice.

One federal note before the states. At the national level, a political party committee must register with the Federal Election Commission once it accepts contributions or makes expenditures above \$1,000 in a calendar year, and the law gives it only ten days after crossing that line to file. That is the whole federal threshold. There is no wealth test to found a party in America. There is only a form, a filing cabinet, and people willing to sign their names.

The states follow in alphabetical order. Each entry covers three things: how a new party gets on the ballot, how its candidates qualify, and what the party must do to keep its place.

## Alabama

A group becomes a full political party in Alabama only when its candidate for a state office draws more than 20 percent of the vote in a general election. Everyone else starts as a minor party. The path: submit the party emblem to the Secretary of State at least 60 days before the primary, then file a certificate of nomination by 5 p.m. on primary day. For statewide ballot access, the party must file a petition signed by at least 3 percent of the total vote cast for governor in the last general election. Minor parties are not required to give notice of the meeting where they nominate candidates. Sources:

<https://www.sos.alabama.gov/alabama-votes> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Alabama](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Alabama). Rules change; call before you file.

## Alaska

Alaska sorts newcomers into two boxes. A political group files a simple application with the director of the Division of Elections, and the state starts tracking how many voters register under its name. A recognized political party needs at least 5,000 registered voters. To convert, a group must file its application and bylaws with the director of elections, and with the U.S. Department of Justice, on or before May 31 of the election year. There is also a limited political party track for presidential races only: file a petition, and the status holds if the party's presidential candidate wins at least 3 percent of the vote. Sources:

<https://www.elections.alaska.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Alaska](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Alaska). Rules change; call before you file.

## Arizona

A new party files a petition with the Secretary of State carrying signatures equal to at least 1.33 percent of the total votes cast for governor at the last general election. Signatures must come from at least five counties, and at least 10 percent of them must come from counties with populations under 500,000. The petition is due at least 250 days before the primary. Recognition runs through the next two general elections. After that, the party must poll 5 percent in the governor's race, or hold the affiliation of 0.67 percent of all registered voters by October 1 of the year before the election, or start over. Sources: [https://azsos.gov/\(state election office\)](https://azsos.gov/(state%20election%20office)); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Arizona](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Arizona). Rules change; call before you file.

## Arkansas

The petition to the Secretary of State needs 10,000 signatures from registered voters, filed at least three weeks before the primary. Signatures cannot be gathered before January 1 of the year following the last general election. Once the petition is certified, the new party nominates its first slate of candidates by convention. If its candidate for governor or for presidential elector pulls at least 3 percent of the vote at that general election, the party keeps its status and may nominate by primary from then on. Miss the 3 percent mark, and the party ceases to exist as a legal party. Sources: <https://www.sos.arkansas.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Arkansas](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Arkansas). Rules change; call before you file.

## California

Three doors. A party qualifies if its candidates polled at least 2 percent of the statewide vote at the last gubernatorial primary, or if voters equal to 0.33 percent of registered voters declare for the party by the 154th day before the primary, or if a petition is filed bearing signatures from 10 percent of the voters who cast ballots in the last gubernatorial election. The petition route runs through county election officials, with the Secretary of State ruling by the 135th day before the primary. To stay qualified, a party needs 2 percent in a statewide race or 0.33 percent registration. Fall below 0.067 percent and the ballot line is gone. Sources: <https://www.sos.ca.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_California](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_California). Rules change; call before you file.

## Colorado

Colorado offers a starter rung called the qualified political organization. File a proof of organization form with bylaws and leadership, meet at least once a year, elect officers in odd-numbered years, pick candidates in even years, and certify at least one candidate every two years. From there, minor party status comes three ways: a statewide candidate takes 5 percent in either of the last two elections; 1,000 registered voters affiliate by July 1; or a petition of 10,000 signatures reaches the Secretary of State by the second Friday of January. Keep status with 1 percent in either of the last two elections, or 1,000 registered affiliates by July 1. Sources: <https://www.coloradosos.gov/pubs/elections/main.html> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Colorado](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Colorado). Rules change; call before you file.

## Connecticut

There is no paperwork phase. A group runs a candidate with a party designation on a nominating petition, and if that candidate wins 1 percent of the vote for the office, a minor party is born, for that office. Hold the status by filing party rules with the Secretary of State, by running a candidate every time the office comes up, and by observing the convention rules: rules on file 60 days before delegates are chosen, written notice to the Secretary of State five days before any nominating convention, and a notice published in a newspaper of general circulation. Major party status requires 20 percent for governor, or 20 percent of registered voters enrolled. Sources: <https://portal.ct.gov/sots/election-services> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Connecticut](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Connecticut). Rules change; call before you file.

## Delaware

Delaware's gate is registration, not petition. A party appears on the general election ballot only if voters affiliated with it, as of 21 days before the primary, equal at least 0.1 percent of all registered voters in the state, counted against the December 31 roster from the year before the election. To count as a major party, that affiliation must reach 5 percent of the state's registered voters by December 31 before a general election year. Everyone else is a minor party. The practical work here is signing people up as registered members, neighbor by neighbor, county by county. Sources: <https://elections.delaware.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Delaware](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Delaware). Rules change; call before you file.

## Florida

A group becomes a minor party by filing a certificate with the Division of Elections: the party name, its officers and executive committee members with a completed uniform voter registration application for each showing their affiliation, and a copy of its constitution, bylaws, and rules. The executive committee then elects a chair, vice chair, secretary, and treasurer. That is the whole doorway. If 5 percent of the state's registered voters sign up by January 1 before a primary, the party is reclassified as a major party. In the primary, multiple candidates of the party face only its own registered members; a single candidate skips straight to the general ballot. Sources: <https://dos.fl.gov/elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Florida](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Florida). Rules change; call before you file.

## Georgia

Georgia calls most new groups political organizations. Register with the Secretary of State within 60 days of forming, with a \$10 filing fee, a charter, bylaws, and officer lists; amendments cost \$2 and are due within 30 days of a change. To nominate candidates by convention, the organization either files a petition signed by voters equal to 1 percent of the registered voters from the preceding general election, or points to a statewide nominee from the last election who drew votes equal to 1 percent of registered voters. Without one of those, its candidates are nominated by petition, exactly as independent candidates are. Full party status requires 20 percent for governor or president. Sources: <https://mvp.sos.ga.gov/s/olvr-home> (Georgia voter-registration portal); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Georgia](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Georgia). Rules change; call before you file.

## Hawaii

Apply to the Office of Elections, which issues the official petition. The signature bar is small: 0.1 percent of the state's registered voters as of the most recent general election. File by the 170th day before the primary, together with the names and addresses of the party's central committee and county committee officers, and a copy of the party rules. A party that qualifies by petition and keeps qualifying for three consecutive elections earns ten years of automatic ballot access, provided it keeps fielding candidates. When the ten years run out, it must hit the vote thresholds again or re-petition. Sources: <https://elections.hawaii.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Hawaii](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Hawaii). Rules change; call before you file.

## Idaho

Three doors. Run three or more candidates under the party name at a general election. Or poll 3 percent of the vote for governor or presidential electors. Or file a petition with the Secretary of State by August 30 of an even-numbered year, signed by electors equal to 2 percent of the vote for presidential electors at the last presidential election. The petition states the party's name in six words or fewer and may not be circulated before August 30 of the year before the election. Once the Secretary of State certifies the petition, the party holds a state convention and nominates like any other party. Sources: <https://vote.idaho.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Idaho](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Idaho). Rules change; call before you file.

## Illinois

The new party petition is the door. Statewide, the requirement is the lesser of 1 percent of the voters who cast ballots at the last general election, or 25,000 signatures. For a congressional or legislative district, it is 5 percent of that district's last general election turnout, or the statewide number, whichever is less. Petitions may be circulated no more than 90 days before the filing deadline. The old full-slate rule, which forced new parties to run a candidate for every office at once, was struck down by the Seventh Circuit Court of Appeals in 2017. A party becomes established when its candidate for governor takes 5 percent, and only established parties run primaries. Sources:

<https://www.elections.il.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Illinois](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Illinois). Rules change; call before you file.

## Indiana

Indiana measures everything against the Secretary of State's race. A party whose candidate finished first or second there is a major party. One that took between 2 and 10 percent may nominate by state, county, or municipal convention. Before recognition, a new party's candidates file by petition, exactly as independents do, except the petition may carry the party's name and device. Take 2 percent for Secretary of State and the party earns the convention route from then on. Reach 10 percent, and it must nominate by primary election, which in Indiana is the mark of arrival. Sources: <https://www.in.gov/sos/elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Indiana](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Indiana). Rules change; call before you file.

## Iowa

A group that is not a party files nothing to exist. It is a nonparty political organization, and each one may nominate a single candidate per partisan office using nomination papers: an affidavit of candidacy plus nomination petitions or a certificate from an organization convention. To become a party, put a candidate for president or governor on the general ballot, win at least 2 percent of the vote for that office, then file an application for party status with the Secretary of State after the canvass, within one year of the election. Hold on by clearing 2 percent at every general election. Fall short, and the status is revoked and the climb begins again. Sources: <https://sos.iowa.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Iowa](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Iowa). Rules change; call before you file.

## Kansas

Petition the Secretary of State with signatures from qualified electors equal to 2 percent of the total vote for governor at the last general election, filed by noon on June 1 before the primary. The name cannot be so long, or so close to an existing party's name, that voters would be confused. Parties whose candidate for governor took 5 percent must nominate by primary. Everyone else nominates at a state convention and files a certified nominee list with the Secretary of State by noon on June 1 of the election year. To keep recognition, a party needs a statewide candidate who wins at least 1 percent of the vote. Sources: <https://www.sos.ks.gov/elections/elections.html> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Kansas](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Kansas). Rules change; call before you file.

## Kentucky

Kentucky requires no paperwork at all to form a party. The state classifies political entities purely by their results in the most recent presidential election. A candidate who took at least 10 percent makes the entity a political party, which nominates by primary. Between 2 and 10 percent makes it a political organization, which may nominate by convention, by primary, or by petition. Below 2 percent is a political group, and a political group's only route to the ballot is the nominating petition. The message is blunt: the party name arrives as a reward for votes already earned. Sources: <https://elect.ky.gov/Pages/default.aspx> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Kentucky](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Kentucky). Rules change; call before you file.

## Louisiana

Two doors. The registration door: 5,000 registered voters affiliated with the party, a notarized registration statement, and a \$5,000 fee, all delivered to the Secretary of State no later than 90 days before the candidate qualifying period opens. The results door: a candidate who took 5 percent in the last presidential election, or 5 percent in a statewide primary or general election. Keep recognition by staying on the ballot; four consecutive years without a qualified primary candidate ends it. One warning for this project: as of August 1, 2025, Louisiana will not recognize any party whose name is simply Independent or any variation on it. Sources: <https://voterportal.sos.la.gov/> (Louisiana voter portal); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Louisiana](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Louisiana). Rules change; call before you file.

## Maine

Two roads. Around a candidate: file a declaration naming a governor or presidential candidate from the last election who was nominated by petition and won at least 5 percent, with that candidate's signed consent, by 5 p.m. on the 180th day before the primary. By enrollment: ten or more voters file a declaration between December 1 and December 30 of an even-numbered year, then gather 5,000 enrolled members by January 2 of the following year. A new party must hold municipal caucuses in the state's 16 counties and a state convention. Keep status with 5 percent for governor or president, or 5,000 enrolled members. Sources: <https://www.maine.gov/sos/cec/elec/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Maine](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Maine). Rules change; call before you file.

## Maryland

File a formation petition naming the party, its chairman, and the 25 registered voters who will form the initial governing body, along with an interim constitution and bylaws. Supporters then have the two years between the first signature and the last to collect 10,000 signatures from eligible voters. Within 90 days of filing, the chairman convenes an organizational meeting to adopt the constitution and bylaws; a copy goes to the state board within 30 days of adoption. Status lasts through the second statewide general election after qualification. After that, keep it by winning 1 percent for the highest office on the ballot, or by holding 1 percent of registered voters as of December 31 each year. Sources: <https://elections.maryland.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Maryland](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Maryland). Rules change; call before you file.

## Massachusetts

A party is any organization that polled 3 percent of the vote for a statewide office at the last statewide election, or that has enrolled 1 percent of the state's registered voters. There is a lighter option called the political designation: up to three words, requested by at least 50 registered voters on a form to the secretary of the commonwealth. Voters enrolled in a designation may still vote in party primaries. The upkeep rule mirrors the entry rule: miss both the 3 percent mark and the 1 percent enrollment mark, and the party ceases to be recognized.

Sources:

<https://www.usvotefoundation.org/vote/state-election-offices.htm> (US Vote Foundation election-office directory); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Massachusetts](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Massachusetts). Rules change; call before you file.

## Michigan

Petition the Secretary of State with signatures equal to 1 percent of all votes cast for governor at the most recent gubernatorial election, including at least 100 signatures from each of at least one half of the state's congressional districts. A certificate signed by the party's chairperson and secretary must reach the Secretary of State by 4 p.m. on the 110th day before the general election. Signatures must be no more than 180 days old when filed, and a sufficiency decision comes no later than 60 days before the election. To keep status, the party's best-performing candidate must win at least 1 percent of the votes cast for the winning Secretary of State candidate. Sources:

<https://www.michigan.gov/sos/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Michigan](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Michigan). Rules change; call before you file.

## Minnesota

Two classes, two ladders. A major party needs a statewide candidate whose votes, cast in every county, total at least 8 percent of all votes cast in the election, or a full slate of 76 candidates, or a petition signed by 5 percent of the voters of the preceding general election collected within one year. A minor party needs the same at 1 percent. Status lasts through two consecutive general elections; keep it by hitting the numbers again within those two. A district-level minor party needs 10 percent there. Minor parties nominate by petition rather than primary, and must certify a constitution, a chair, and a convention to the Secretary of State by December 31. Sources:

<https://www.sos.state.mn.us/elections-voting/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Minnesota](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Minnesota). Rules change; call before you file.

## Mississippi

The gentlest entry in the country. No petitions, no fees, and no vote minimums to keep recognition. The chairman of the party's state executive committee files a registration application with the Secretary of State within 30 days of the party's organization, accompanied by an affidavit listing the members of the executive committee, its chairman and secretary, the national committeeman and committeewoman, and the party's officers. The only real restriction is the name: it cannot match, or be deceptively similar to, any political body already registered. Organize, file, and the party exists in the eyes of the state. Sources: <https://www.ms.gov/> (Mississippi state government homepage); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Mississippi](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Mississippi). Rules change; call before you file.

## Missouri

Petition the Secretary of State. Statewide, the petition needs 10,000 registered voters. For a single district, the requirement is the lesser of 2 percent of the votes cast at the last election for the office sought, or 10,000. Each page must declare the intent to form a new party and give the party's name in five words or fewer. The window opens at 8 a.m. the day after one general election and closes at 5 p.m. on the 15th Monday before the general the party wants to enter. The first slate is nominated however the bylaws prescribe; after that, nominations go through the primary. Keep status with more than 2 percent in either of the last two elections. Sources: <https://www.sos.mo.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Missouri](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Missouri). Rules change; call before you file.

## Montana

The petition must carry signatures equal to 5 percent of the votes cast for the winning gubernatorial candidate, or 5,000 electors, whichever is less, and must include voters from at least one third of the state's legislative districts, with at least 5 percent, or 150 electors, in each of those districts. Four weeks before the filing deadline, the petition and circulation affidavits go to the county election administrator where the signatures were gathered for verification; the administrator forwards them to the Secretary of State at least 95 days before the primary. A party whose statewide candidate drew 5 percent in either of the last two elections nominates by primary. Sources: <https://sosmt.gov/Elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Montana](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Montana). Rules change; call before you file.

## Nebraska

File a sample petition with the Secretary of State before circulating anything. The finished petition needs signatures equal to 1 percent of the vote for governor at the most recent election, spread so that each of the three congressional districts supplies at least 1 percent. The deadline is January 15 to enter the primary, July 15 for the general. The Secretary of State rules on sufficiency within 20 business days, and a certified party then has 20 days to file its constitution, bylaws, and a list of officers. Keep access by holding 10,000 registered affiliates, or by a 5 percent statewide showing, or a combination of district races adding up to 5 percent, in one of the last two elections. Sources: <https://sos.nebraska.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Nebraska](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Nebraska). Rules change; call before you file.

## Nevada

File a certificate of existence with the Secretary of State, along with the party's constitution or bylaws, which must provide a nomination procedure allowing one candidate per office. Then prove support: signatures equal to 1 percent of the votes cast for U.S. Representative at the last general election, apportioned equally among the state's four districts, filed by June 1. Alternatives: a party candidate already won 1 percent at the last election, or 1 percent of registered voters declared for the party by January 1. A notarized candidate list goes in during the filing period, or a notice of continued existence by the second Friday in August. Keep status with 1 percent of the vote or 1 percent registration. Sources: <https://www.nvsos.gov/sos/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Nevada](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Nevada). Rules change; call before you file.

## New Hampshire

Recognition belongs to any political organization whose candidate won at least 4 percent of the vote for governor or United States Senator at the last state general election. Everyone else petitions: valid signatures equal to 3 percent of the total votes cast at the previous state general election, with no one signing more than one organization's paper. The chairman files a declaration of intent during the June filing period, and petition papers land by 5 p.m. on the Wednesday one week before the primary. Recognized parties nominate by primary. Between the third Tuesday of September and the last Tuesday of October, the party holds a state convention to adopt a platform and set its organization. Sources: <https://www.usa.gov/state-election-office> (USA.gov election-office directory); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_New\\_Hampshire](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_New_Hampshire). Rules change; call before you file.

## New Jersey

The bar is a single number. A party is any organization whose candidates polled at least 10 percent of the total vote cast for the General Assembly at the preceding election. Candidates petition onto the ballot with a designation of three words or fewer, which is printed beside their names. Reach 10 percent, and the party may nominate by primary; keep reaching it, and the status holds. Before that milestone, New Jersey's newcomers run and vote through petition designations, one office and one election at a time, accumulating a name the way a riverbank accumulates silt. Sources: <https://www.nj.gov/state/elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_New\\_Jersey](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_New_Jersey). Rules change; call before you file.

## New Mexico

File party rules with the Secretary of State, uniform county rules with the county clerks, and a petition carrying valid signatures equal to 0.5 percent of the vote for governor at the last general election. Everything is due within 30 days of the party's organization, and no later than 23 days after the primary before the election the party intends to enter. Rule amendments are barred within 120 days of a general election and take effect 30 days after filing. A party loses status by skipping two elections in a row, or by a governor or presidential candidate drawing under 0.5 percent. Major status requires 5 percent of the vote plus one third of one percent of the state's registered voters. Sources:

<https://www.sos.nm.gov/voting-and-elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_New\\_Mexico](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_New_Mexico). Rules change; call before you file.

## New York

There is no advance registration for parties. A political organization runs a candidate for governor or president through the independent nomination process, printing its chosen name on the petition, and the name appears on the ballot beside the candidate. If the candidate wins at least 2 percent of the vote for the office, or 130,000 votes, whichever is greater, the organization is recognized as a party. It then forms state and county committees, files its rules within 10 days of adopting them, nominates by its own rules the first time, and by primary thereafter. Fall below the number, and the party's voters are unenrolled; the climb starts again. Sources: <https://www.ny.gov/services/register-vote> (New York voter-registration service); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_New\\_York](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_New_York). Rules change; call before you file.

## North Carolina

Three doors. A candidate for governor or presidential elector polls 2 percent of the statewide vote. Or a petition reaches the State Board of Elections by noon on June 1 with signatures equal to 0.25 percent of the voters who voted for governor, including at least 200 registered voters from each of three congressional districts; petitions go to the county chairman for verification 15 days before the state deadline. Or documentation that the group placed a presidential candidate on the general election ballots of at least 70 percent of the states at the prior presidential election. A newly qualified party selects its first nominees by convention. Sources: <https://www.ncsbe.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_North\\_Carolina](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_North_Carolina). Rules change; call before you file.

## North Dakota

A party may nominate on the primary ballot once it has organized under state law, and its candidates for presidential electors, governor, attorney general, or secretary of state took at least 5 percent of the vote at the last general election. Short of that, a political organization files a petition with the Secretary of State signed by at least 7,000 qualified electors, by 4 p.m. on the 64th day before the primary, naming the organization, stating its platform principles, and listing the candidates it wants on the primary ballot. The 5 percent test is also the upkeep test. Miss it, and the party re-petitions. Sources: <https://vip.sos.nd.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_North\\_Dakota](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_North_Dakota). Rules change; call before you file.

## Ohio

A party exists on two conditions. Its candidate for governor, or its nominees for presidential electors, polled at least 3 percent of the vote at the most recent regular state election, which buys four years of status. Or it files a party formation petition: signatures equal to at least 1 percent of the vote for governor or presidential electors, with at least 500 qualified electors from each of at least half the congressional districts, a declared party name, and a committee of three to five petitioners, filed for an election held more than 125 days after filing. The Secretary of State blocks names likely to confuse voters with an existing party. Sources: <https://www.voteohio.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Ohio](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Ohio). Rules change; call before you file.

## Oklahoma

File a notice of intent with the State Election Board, at any time except between March 1 and November 15 of even-numbered years. Then circulate a qualifying petition for up to one year, collecting signatures equal to 3 percent of the vote for governor at the last general election, never gathering between March 1 and November 15 of an even year. File by March 1 of an election year to reach that year's ballot. Recognized parties nominate by primary. Keep status with at least 2.5 percent for any statewide office in either of the last two elections. A party that slips becomes a political organization, and the designation terminates after four years unless the party re-qualifies. Sources: <https://oklahoma.gov/elections.html> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Oklahoma](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Oklahoma). Rules change; call before you file.

## Oregon

File a signed prospective petition with the Secretary of State, then gather signatures equal to 1.5 percent of the votes cast for all candidates for governor at the most recent election at which a governor was elected to a full term. The completed petition is due within two years of that first filing. Keep status one of two ways: registration equal to 0.25 percent of the state's electors, or 0.1 percent registration plus at least one candidate polling 1 percent for presidential elector or a single statewide office once in any four-year period. Minor parties nominate by convention and must file their organizational documents within 30 days of adopting them. Sources: <https://sos.oregon.gov/elections/pages/default.aspx> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Oregon](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Oregon). Rules change; call before you file.

## Pennsylvania

Pennsylvania grades on two curves. Party status comes from a candidate who polled at least 2 percent of the largest countywide vote in each of at least ten counties and 2 percent of the largest statewide vote, or 5 percent of the largest countywide vote in any single county at the preceding general or municipal election. Parties whose statewide registration is under 15 percent of the combined registration of all statewide parties are minor parties: no primaries, and candidates qualify through nomination papers bearing a body name of three words or fewer printed on the ballot. The giants hold the primaries. Everyone else petitions. Sources: <https://www.vote.pa.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Pennsylvania](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Pennsylvania). Rules change; call before you file.

## Rhode Island

A political organization becomes a party by nominating a candidate for governor or president who wins 5 percent of the vote, or by petition: signatures from registered voters equal to 5 percent of the votes cast for governor or president at the last election, none collected before January 1 of the target year. Petition-qualified status lasts only for that year. File the organization's name, chairperson, and secretary with the board of elections when the petitions go in. The deadline is June 1 for parties nominating by primary, August 1 for any other method. Keep recognition the way it was won: 5 percent for governor or president, or start over. Sources: <https://elections.ri.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Rhode\\_Island](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Rhode_Island). Rules change; call before you file.

## South Carolina

Petition the state election commission for certification at least six months before the election, with 10,000 or more registered electors, and a name substantially different from any previously certified party. Then organize like you mean it: county conventions before March 31 of each general election year, a state convention before May 15 publicly announced at least ten days ahead, and nominations by convention or party primary. The party must certify candidates in at least one of any two consecutive November general elections, or in an election between them. Miss that rhythm and the certification lapses. The state wants to see a living organization, not a name on file. Sources: <https://scvotes.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_South\\_Carolina](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_South_Carolina). Rules change; call before you file.

## South Dakota

A party is any group whose candidate for a statewide office received at least 2.5 percent of the vote in either of the two previous general elections. A new party organizes by filing a petition with the Secretary of State by 5 p.m. on the last Tuesday of March before the primary, signed by registered voters equal to 1 percent of the vote for governor at the last gubernatorial election. The written declaration must carry the party's name and a brief statement of its principles. The party then adopts a constitution or bylaws, filed with any amendments within 30 days of approval, and joins the primary. Sources:

<https://sdsos.gov/elections-voting/default.aspx> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_South\\_Dakota](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_South_Dakota). Rules change; call before you file.

## Tennessee

Petition the Coordinator of Elections with signatures equal to 2.5 percent of the vote for governor at the last gubernatorial election, the petition's purpose, the party's name, and signatures of registered voters from a single county. Petitions are issued no more than 90 days before the qualifying deadline. Before any name touches a ballot, the party's officers file two things with the Secretary of State and the coordinator: an affidavit that the party does not advocate overthrow of any government by force, and the party's rules, with amendments filed within 30 days and effective ten days after filing. Keep the ballot with a 5 percent statewide showing, which also brings automatic access. Sources: <https://sos.tn.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Tennessee](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Tennessee). Rules change; call before you file.

## Texas

Form an organization with a name of three words or fewer, elect a chair, and file party rules with the Secretary of State covering convention procedure, the selection of presidential electors, and the choosing of officers and delegates. A party making state nominations also establishes a state executive committee and posts all its rules on its website. The nominating ladder runs from precinct conventions up through county, district, and state conventions, each chair certifying nominees within 20 days. Ballot access requires precinct convention participants totaling 1 percent of all votes for governor at the last gubernatorial election, made up by petition if short. Keep the ballot with a statewide nominee at 5 percent. Sources: <https://www.votetexas.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Texas](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Texas). Rules change; call before you file.

## Utah

A registered party files a petition with the lieutenant governor signed by at least 2,000 registered voters, stating a party name of no more than four words and an emblem distinguishable from every other party's. Its candidates then reach the primary ballot by gathering petition signatures. Full qualified party status, under the state's signature-and-convention law, lets candidates pursue the nomination through the party's convention system, or by petition, or both. Whichever level a party holds, it keeps it only if one of its candidates wins at least 2 percent of all votes cast for the United States House of Representatives in the same regular general election. Sources: <https://vote.utah.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Utah](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Utah). Rules change; call before you file.

## Vermont

Vermont organizes from the ground up, in odd-numbered years. Three voters in a town call a caucus, noticed at the town clerk's office at least five days ahead, and elect a town committee with a chair, vice chair, secretary, treasurer, and assistant treasurer; certified lists go to the Secretary of State, the state chair, and the town clerk within 72 hours. A minor party may skip the county tier unless it wants to nominate state senate candidates. The state committee certifies its officers, and by January 1 of the election year the party files a certificate showing organization in at least 30 towns. Major parties, at 5 percent, nominate by primary; minors nominate by party committee. Sources: <https://sos.vermont.gov/elections/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Vermont](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Vermont). Rules change; call before you file.

## Virginia

Organize first: a state central committee with one registered voter from each congressional district and two from the commonwealth at large, a party plan, bylaws, and a chairman and secretary in place at least six months before the petition. Then petition: 10,000 qualified voters, including 400 from each congressional district, all signing on or after January 1 of the election year, filed with the state board of elections by noon on the 74th day before the election. Official recognition, and the party label beside statewide candidates, arrives when a party candidate wins at least 10 percent of the vote for a statewide office in either of the last two elections. Sources: <https://www.elections.virginia.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Virginia](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Virginia). Rules change; call before you file.

## Washington

The easiest state in the union for a new label. Under the top-two primary, any candidate simply lists the party they prefer, and the law requires no conventions and no signatures, and does not even dictate how a party conducts its nominations. A major political party is one whose nominees for president and vice president took at least 5 percent of the vote at the last presidential election; every other organization is a minor party. The parties decide their own nomination methods for themselves. Ballot fights in Washington are won by filing candidates on time, not by petitioning anyone. Sources:

<https://www.sos.wa.gov/elections> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Washington](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Washington). Rules change; call before you file.

## West Virginia

A party is any affiliation of voters whose candidate for governor polled at least 1 percent of the total vote at the last general election. Until then, independents carry the flag: a candidate may choose a political designation of no more than five words and specify it on the nominating petition form. A party, in fact, can only be formed by running a candidate under a party designation and letting the votes accumulate. One percent is the whole law. The gate at the start is light, the gate for keeping is light, and every general election offers a fresh chance to cross. Sources: <https://sos.wv.gov/elections/Pages/default.aspx> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_West\\_Virginia](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_West_Virginia). Rules change; call before you file.

## Wisconsin

Three routes. A candidate for any statewide office took at least 1 percent at the last gubernatorial election, or 1 percent at a general that coincided with a presidential election. An organization that was listed as independent and met that same test asks the Wisconsin Elections Commission for ballot status by 5 p.m. on April 1 of an election year. Or petition with the signatures of at least 10,000 qualified electors, including at least 1,000 from each of three separate congressional districts, also by April 1, for status through that year's general election. Parties with ballot status nominate by primary, and keep it by repeating the 1 percent test each cycle. Sources: <https://elections.wi.gov/> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Wisconsin](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Wisconsin). Rules change; call before you file.

## Wyoming

File a petition with the Secretary of State by May 1 of the election year, signed by electors equal to 2 percent of the vote for Wyoming's at-large U.S. representative at the last general election, after the Secretary has approved the petition's form. Party names may run two words, must not resemble an existing party's, and cannot include the word independent. The filed party enters the next general election as a provisional party, nominating by convention, with statewide nominees certified to the Secretary of State by the day before the primary, and county nominees to the county clerk. Minor status runs from 2 to 10 percent. Major status, with its own primaries, begins at 10. Sources: <https://sos.wyo.gov/Elections/Default.aspx> (state election office); Ballotpedia: [https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot\\_access\\_requirements\\_for\\_political\\_parties\\_in\\_Wyoming](https://ballotpedia.org/Ballot_access_requirements_for_political_parties_in_Wyoming). Rules change; call before you file.

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Fifty states, fifty doors, and not one of them asks whether a party is liberal or conservative. They ask whether it can organize a meeting, gather signatures, and show up on time. That is the entire secret the ballot laws keep. The duopoly is not protected by money alone. It is protected by the assumption, repeated until it

feels like physics, that none of us will ever do the paperwork.